Third System
AI Presence Index

Five Months On

The same 112 brands, the same six AI models, the same questions, five months apart. The standings held, and the brands the models never mention are still not mentioned.

November 2026 · Pablo Ulpiano González Castro

AIAS™ Measurement Program

A brand measure is only worth managing if it holds still while nothing about the brand changes. In June, Third System™ showed that AI brand standings survive three weeks. In November we asked the same six models the same questions about the same 112 brands once more, 152 days later, and just before those models begin to retire. Both of the AIAS™ scores, Presence and Consistency, kept their order. Neither showed any sign of fading with time.

Consistency rank order held from June to November across 80 brands (0.68), above the level the questions alone would produce. Presence held in all five categories (0.93 to 0.98). A brand's Consistency and its Presence moved independently of each other. And 56 of 58 brands below the recall floor in June were still below it in November.

Four findings and one observation. First, Consistency: which brands the models agree on, and which they split on, stayed the same over five months. Second, Presence: how often each brand is named kept its order in every category, with correlations between 0.93 and 0.98. Third, time: the five-month comparison was as stable as the three-week one for both scores; we found no fading. Fourth, independence: when a brand's Consistency moved, its Presence did not move with it. The two scores are separate signals, which is why the program now reports them side by side rather than blended into one number. The observation: almost every brand the models did not name in June was still unnamed in November.

The implication for brand teams: a brand's standing in AI answers has inertia measured in months, not weeks. It does not drift away on its own, and it does not improve by waiting. Absence in particular is a durable condition.

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What we measured

This is the third measurement of five category panels first measured in May 2026: audiophile headphones (16 brands), and skincare, cosmetics, automotive and premium spirits (24 each). The second wave ran in June, 15 to 21 days after the first. The third ran on 9 November, 152 days after the second, with the brand lists, the question wording and the six models (two each from Anthropic, OpenAI and Google) unchanged. For the four models that report a dated version, we confirmed it was the same version as in June.

Presence measures how often a model names a brand when a buyer-style question is asked without prompting. Consistency measures whether the six models agree about that brand, or whether some name it reliably and others ignore it; it uses the program's current Consistency method, adopted in July, which does not rise and fall with how often a brand is named. The method, the tests and the pass marks were registered publicly before the first November question was sent, and all 852 questions returned an answer.

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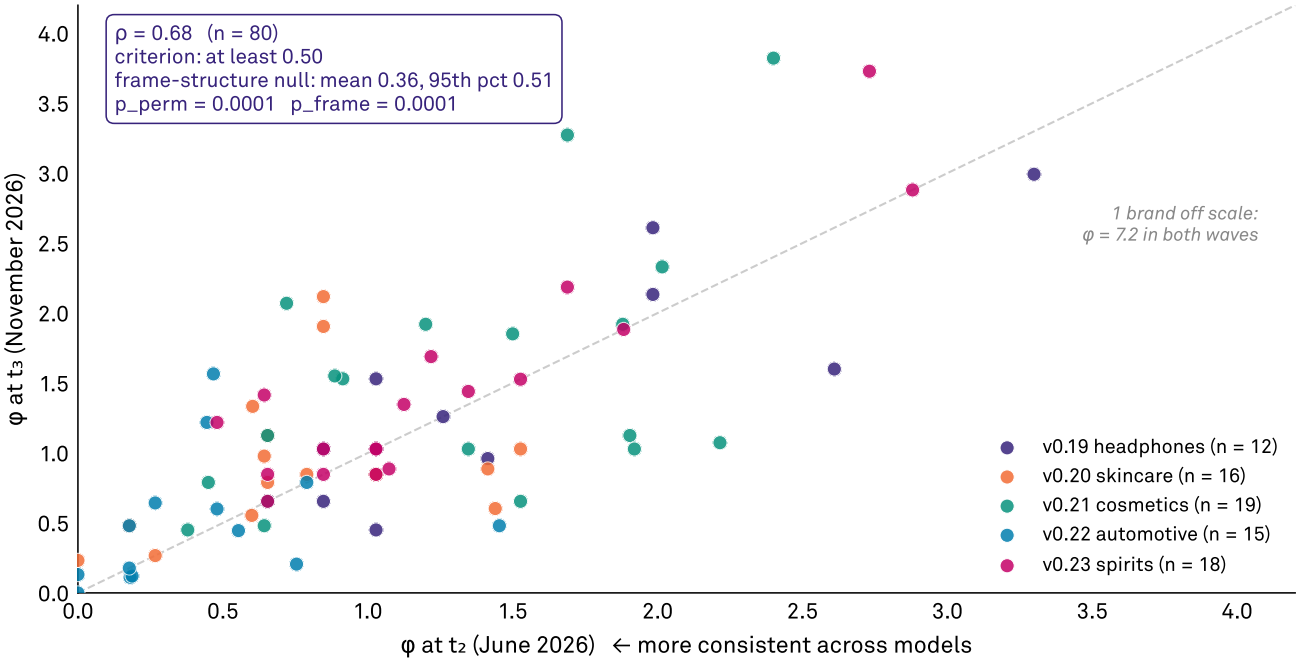
FINDING 01

The models agreed on the same brands five months later

Consistency keeps its brand order over five months

Per-brand φ (between-model dispersion; lower = more consistent), June vs November 2026, φ defined in both waves.

The order beats both nulls: shuffled brands and models scrambled within each question. Dashed: no change.



P1 SUPPORTED — which brands the AI models agree on stayed the same over five months, beyond what the questions alone explain.

Source: AIAS™ v0.41 (Long-Horizon Stability t1→t2→t3) | Protocol v0.41-prereg-r1 | Third System™

Each brand's Consistency score in June plotted against November, for the 80 brands scored in both waves; lower means the six models agree more. Points follow the dashed no-change line, with visible spread around it. One headphones brand sits off the scale, at the maximum score in both waves.

Across the 80 brands with a Consistency score in both June and November, the brand order correlated at 0.68 (12 headphones, 16 skincare, 19 cosmetics, 15 automotive and 18 spirits brands). The registered bar was 0.50, and the result also had to beat two chance baselines: shuffled brand labels, and a scramble of which model answered within each question. It beat both; the scrambles averaged 0.36 and never exceeded 0.66. Leaving out any one category, the figure stays between 0.64 and 0.73.

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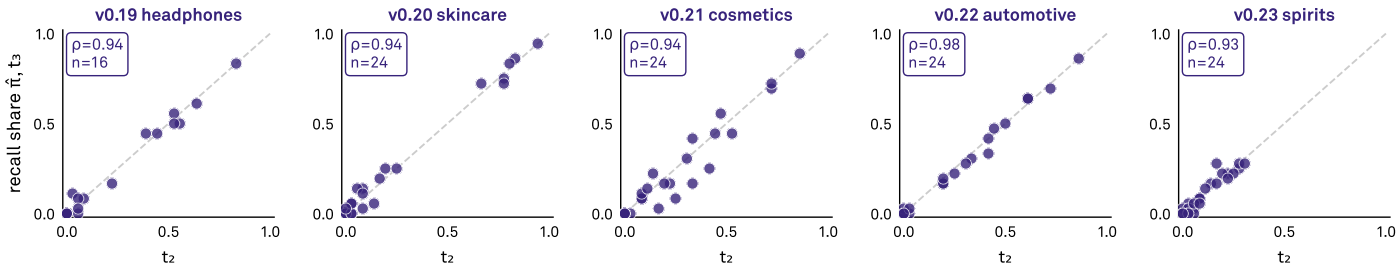
FINDING 02

Presence kept its order in every category

Presence keeps its brand order in every category

Per-brand recall share π̂ (share of the 36 model × question answers that name the brand), June vs November.

Criterion: ρ of at least 0.70 in at least four of five categories; all five pass.



P2 SUPPORTED — how often each brand is named kept its order in every category over five months.

Source: AIAS™ v0.41 (Long-Horizon Stability t1→t2→t3) | Protocol v0.41-prereg-r1 | Third System™

Each brand's Presence (the share of question-and-model answers that name it) in June against November, one panel per category. Every category keeps its order, with correlations from 0.93 to 0.98.

Rank correlation of Presence between June and November: headphones 0.94, skincare 0.94, cosmetics 0.94, automotive 0.98, spirits 0.93. Every category cleared the registered bar of 0.70, and unlike recognition in the earlier waves, Presence showed no ceiling: no brand was named in every question by every model.

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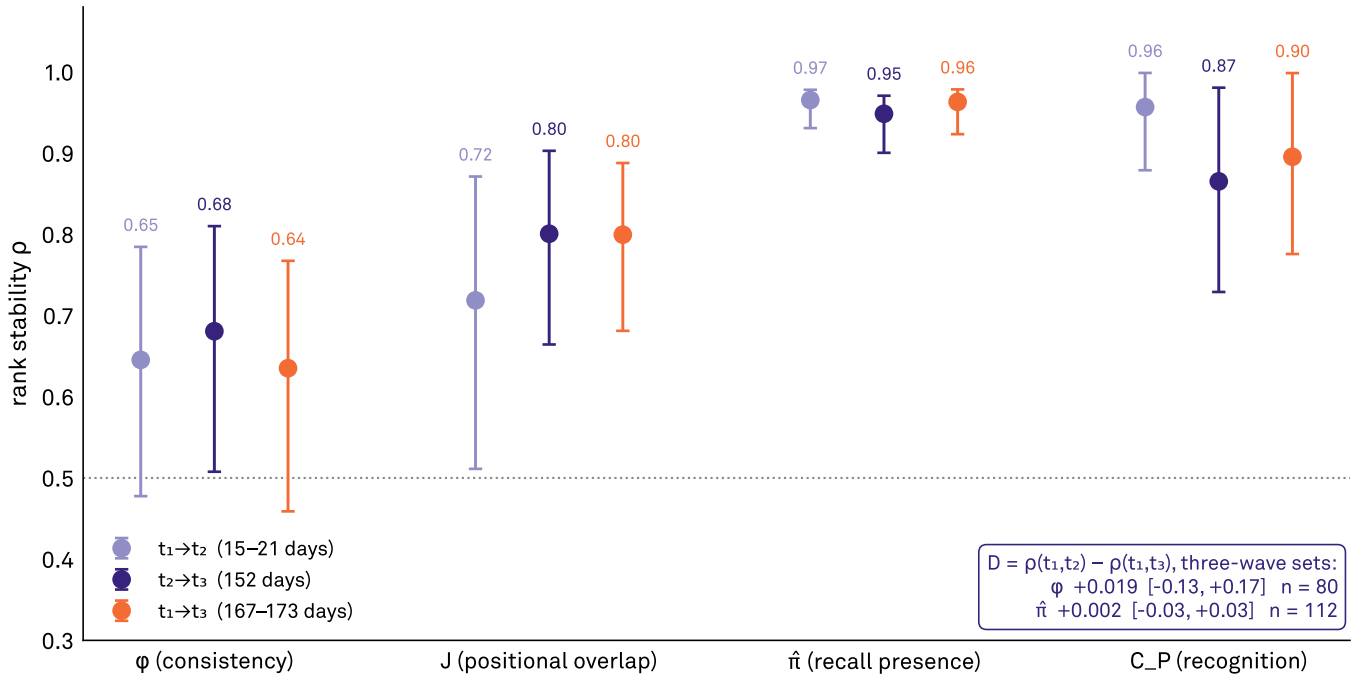
FINDING 03

Five months was as stable as three weeks

Five months is as stable as three weeks

Rank stability by horizon for four instruments; whiskers = descriptive 95% bootstrap intervals (2,000 resamples).

φ and J: pooled Spearman; π̂ and C_P: pooled within-category ranks. Pairwise definedness per horizon.



P3 NO FADING DETECTED — five months was as stable as three weeks, for both scores.

Source: AIAS™ v0.41 (Long-Horizon Stability t1→t2→t3) | Protocol v0.41-prereg-r1 | Third System™

Rank stability at three horizons: three weeks (May to June), five months (June to November) and five and a half months (May to November). Bars show the range of plausible values. For both Consistency and Presence the differences between horizons are small and fall within those ranges.

Measured from May, Consistency's brand order correlated at 0.66 three weeks later and 0.64 five and a half months later. Presence: 0.965 and 0.963. Both differences are smaller than their margins of error, so the study detects no decay. That is a finding of no change, not proof that none exists.

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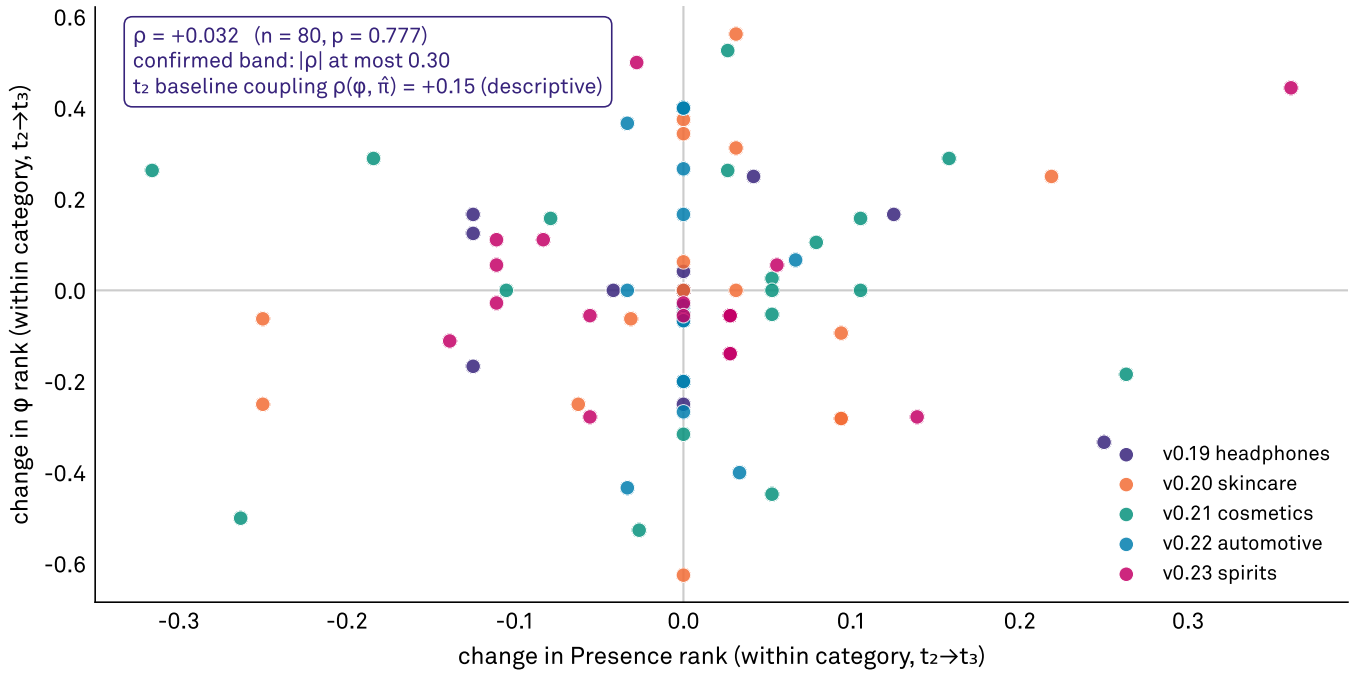
FINDING 04

Two scores, two separate signals

Consistency and Presence change independently

Per-brand change in within-category percentile rank, June to November, brands with φ defined in both waves.

No relationship: a brand gaining or losing presence does not gain or lose consistency with it.



P4 SUPPORTED — when a brand's consistency changes, its presence does not change with it: two separate signals.

Source: AIAS™ v0.41 (Long-Horizon Stability t1→t2→t3) | Protocol v0.41-prereg-r1 | Third System™

How far each brand's Consistency rank moved from June to November against how far its Presence rank moved. The cloud has no direction: a brand gaining or losing Presence did not gain or lose Consistency with it.

For each brand we compared how far its Consistency rank moved from June to November with how far its Presence rank moved. The two movements were unrelated (0.03). Even at a single point in time the two scores are only weakly related (0.15), which supports reporting them separately.

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Invisibility lasts

Brands below the recall floor in June that were still below it in November: headphones 8 of 8, skincare 15 of 15, cosmetics 9 of 10, automotive 10 of 10, spirits 14 of 15. Pooled, 56 of 58 (97%). Over the first three weeks the figure was 56 of 57.

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Limitations

Part of Consistency's stability comes from the question set itself. When we scrambled which model gave which answer within each question, the brand order still repeated at 0.36 on average. The observed 0.68 exceeded every one of 10,000 scrambled versions, but the share of stability that belongs to the brand is smaller than the headline figure alone suggests.

Consistency could be computed for 80 of the 112 brands; the other 32 went unnamed in at least one of the two waves, so there was no agreement to measure. The panels are small (16 to 24 brands), the categories are five mature consumer markets, and the models are one generation old and answer from their training alone, without web search. Stability here is stability of the measurement, not proof that it tracks sales or preference. And because these models are being retired, this exact panel cannot be re-run: these are the last data it can provide.

What’s next

The program's next synthesis treats Presence and Consistency as two separate scores reported side by side, and this study supplies the long-horizon evidence that both are stable enough to report. Consistency will be rated only for brands named often enough for agreement to mean something.

Measurement continues on the current generation of models, with web search off and on. Whether brand standings carry across a change of model generation, and what actually moves a brand across the recall floor, are the open questions for brand teams.

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The five propositions, scored

Each proposition is the managerial reading of a locked result, scored for brand teams rather than reviewers.

#	Proposition	Status
P1	Consistency standings hold over five months.	**SUPPORTED — rank order 0.68 across 80 brands, above every one of 10,000 scrambled baselines**
P2	Presence standings hold over five months.	**SUPPORTED — 5 of 5 categories at or above the registered bar of 0.70**
P3	Standings fade as the interval grows.	*NO FADING DETECTED — the three-week and five-month figures differ by less than their margin of error, for both scores*
P4	Consistency and Presence change independently.	**SUPPORTED — change in one is unrelated to change in the other (0.03 across 80 brands)**
P5	AI invisibility persists over five months.	*OBSERVED — descriptive; 56 of 58 below-floor brands kept the status; no pass mark was set*

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The first wave showed that AI systems hold measurable brand standings. The second showed that they survive three weeks. This third wave shows that they survive five months, for both of the scores the program now reports, and that the two scores move independently. A standing that holds this long is one a brand can set out to change on purpose, and measure whether it did.

About the Third System

The Third System describes a shift in how consumers make decisions: instead of browsing and comparing options directly, many now rely on AI systems to generate recommendations. In this environment, brands compete not only for human attention but for inclusion within AI-generated outputs. This creates a new competitive layer where visibility is determined by how AI systems interpret and surface brands.

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Third System™ (research entity)

Methodology

This report presents findings from Third System's AI Availability research program. The AI Availability Score (AIAS) is an early-stage measurement framework introduced in Tri-System Brand Growth (Gonzalez Castro, 2026). Findings should be used directionally. Construct validity — the correlation between AI Availability and consumer behavior — has not yet been established and is the subject of Phase 3 of the research program. Methodology is published in full and versioned at thirdsystem.ai/methodology (current: v1.8). Registry construction is curated and reflects the framework's view of each category's competitive set; revisions are documented in the methodology log.

Citation

González Castro, P. U. (2026). *Five Months On: Long-Horizon Stability of AI Brand Consistency and Presence Across Five Categories (AIAS v0.41)*. Third System (SSRN pending). thirdsystem.ai/v41

Underlying datasets

Verdicts: osf.io/ec6wh/v41/v41_verdicts.json

Third-wave acquisition data: osf.io/ec6wh/v41/data/

Scoring code: osf.io/ec6wh/v41/scripts/score_v41.py

Pre-registration: osf.io/ec6wh/v41/prereg/ (tag v0.41-prereg-r1)

Methodology log: v0.41 (SSRN pending).

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